

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

MONDAY, AUGUST 24, 2026

At a crossroad, US and Vt. policies clash

Deputy assisted in arrest of man later deported, despite ban on such help

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

At first, Alex Jimenez wasn't overly concerned when a Vermont sheriff's deputy pulled over the car he was riding in last month on a dirt road near the Canadian border. The 22-year-old Mexican farmworker was in the United States illegally, but he knew police officers in Vermont are strictly limited in enforcing federal immigration law.

"I thought he would just stop us, do what he needed to do, and then

we'd be on our way," Jimenez said through an interpreter. "I didn't think I had any reason to be afraid."

But the deputy, Sergeant Scott Costella, did something unusual. After obtaining a license from the driver of the Chevrolet Spark, who was a US citizen, the sheriff's deputy returned to his cruiser and used his personal cellphone to text his location to two US Border Patrol agents, public records show.

"Need one of you," Costella wrote.

When the federal agents arrived, they questioned the vehicle's occupants and, with Costella's assistance, took Jimenez into custody. After three weeks of detention in US Immigration and Customs Enforcement facilities around the country, Jimenez was deported to Mexico.

The episode has reignited a longstanding debate in Vermont over the extent police officers can cooperate with federal immigration authorities. And it's renewed scrutiny of the obscure federal program in which Costella was participating that day.

The program, Operation Stone-

garden, provides overtime pay and equipment to local, county, and state law enforcement agencies that help federal authorities patrol the US border. A Globe investigation last year found 49 agencies in northern New England received more than \$2 million through Stonegarden during the most recent funding period.

Critics of the program have long warned it conflicts with Vermont's Fair and Impartial Policing policies, which largely bar officers from facilitating federal immigration detentions or sharing certain information with the feds. They say the policies

BORDER, Page A7

Option for power rate comes with volatility

As Mass. looks into ways to cut bills, N.H.'s troubles could provide lesson

By Hiawatha Bray
GLOBE STAFF

As Massachusetts politicians scramble to respond to public anger over high electric bills, they are reviewing a different way for utilities to purchase electric power, one that had benefited some buyers but is under fire in neighboring New Hampshire.

Instead of utilities buying all their electricity months in advance, as in the current setup, the proposal would require them to purchase at least some power on the "spot market," where prices can fluctuate from day to day.

Part of broader efforts to rein in utility bills that are among the highest in the nation, the spot-market proposal has gained currency after a recent report asserting power generating companies are charging excessive prices for advance-purchase contracts.

It's a concept that's worked well for the city government of Boston, which for the past decade has bought all its electricity on the spot market, claiming about \$60 million in savings as a result.

But spot buying has been a bust so far in New Hampshire, which just announced rate increases because surging gas prices earlier this year led to a spike in electricity bought on the spot market.

That isn't discouraging regulators in Connecticut.

ELECTRICITY, Page A10

In Medford, a change in who answers the call

Mayor, ambulance service in a scrap over payments

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

By his own admission, Richard Raymond's time in Medford ended on a sour note: There was a disagreement between his company, Armstrong Ambulance, and the city over a contract provision that could not be bridged.

To hear Raymond tell it, his relationship with Medford, where Armstrong had provided 911 response for more than 25 years, fell apart after he says he was asked last year to do something he didn't think was legal: Pay the city a lump sum of \$450,000.

"To me, that's a shakedown," said Raymond, who is Armstrong's chief executive.

Months after that request, and despite Raymond's attempts to find a middle ground, Armstrong no longer covered the city of 60,000, located off Interstate 93 a few miles from Boston.

The story of Armstrong and Medford offers a window into the unusual business of ambulance service in Massachusetts cities, while adding to the cavalcade of claims that Medford Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn's administration is deploying a

MEDFORD, Page A7



PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Ben Murphy, Luke Greenberg, and Sam Stubbs helped harvest onions (below) at Barrett's Mill Farm in Concord.

LATEST SCOURGE FOR FARMERS: FUEL COSTS

Much of their work requires gas and diesel, yet no price relief in sight

By Omar Mohammed
GLOBE STAFF



Concord
Melissa Maxwell has been searching for ways to reduce her small farm's dependence on two diesel- and three gas-powered tractors, with fuel costs remaining abnormally high and no hint that they might return to normal. On a farm, that's obviously difficult.

Fuel prices have soared since the start of the US-Iran war six months ago. For Maxwell and her business partner, Lise Holdorf, fuel costs at Barrett's Mill Farm are up 76 percent. They're concerned that over time people may buy less of their products — dozens of varieties of vegetables, some fruits, and flowers — amid their own worsening financial situations.

"High fuel costs have a double effect on farms like [ours]," said Maxwell,

FARMERS, Page A10

At Grand Prix, politics in the rear view

The usual glacial pace of D.C. gives way to 200-mph IndyCars

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Military fighter jets, television helicopters, Air Force One, and a living, breathing bald eagle all soared above a red, white, and blued-out National Mall Sunday afternoon. But for the vast majority of the tens of thousands of people assembled in and around the Mall, their eyes were glued to the ground.

That's where 25 IndyCars zoomed at nearly 200 miles per hour on a course that transformed downtown D.C. into a speedway.

The track's seven turns directed drivers past the US Capitol, across Pennsylvania Avenue, around a Department of Justice

GRAND PRIX, Page A6



ALEX KENT/NEW YORK TIMES

With the Washington Monument as a backdrop, IndyCars raced by.



Sol survivor

Monday: Sun returns, warmer. High 81-86, low 62-67.

Tuesday: Mostly sunny. High 77-82, low 62-67.

Sunrise: 6:01. Sunset: 7:32.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 310, NO. 55

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



The Boston Symphony Orchestra announced that a contract "ratification vote" may be near, a hopeful sign of progress in negotiations after the musicians authorized a strike. **B1.**

The Suffolk district attorney's race puts the record of incumbent Kevin Hayden to the test. **B1.**

Women doctors can face myriad obstacles — sham peer reviews, harassment, bullying — on their paths to become leaders in medicine, Kara Miller writes. **D1.**

Phoenix's impressive expansion over the decades has been due in large part to diverted water but now that spigot may be turned off. **A2.**

The Red Sox completed a three-game sweep of the Giants with a 5-4 victory. **C1.**